

State Review Learnings:

ArPEP

Alternative Route

On-Site Review: October 15-16, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

ArPEP

Alternative Route

Overall Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
BELOW	APPROACHING	EXCEEDS

Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion

Standard 1 Performance Level		
BELOW		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	BELOW	BELOW
Recommendations		
Recommendations to strengthen candidate recruitment and completion include: - Recruiting additional candidates to increase overall enrollment, and particularly in subject shortage areas, will support the program's Standard 1 performance moving forward. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 1.2a)</i> - Consider what additional supports candidates may need to increase the 3-year completion rate. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 1.3a)</i>		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	ArPEP presented a comprehensive analysis of its program that met all indicators

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	-12.4%	BELOW

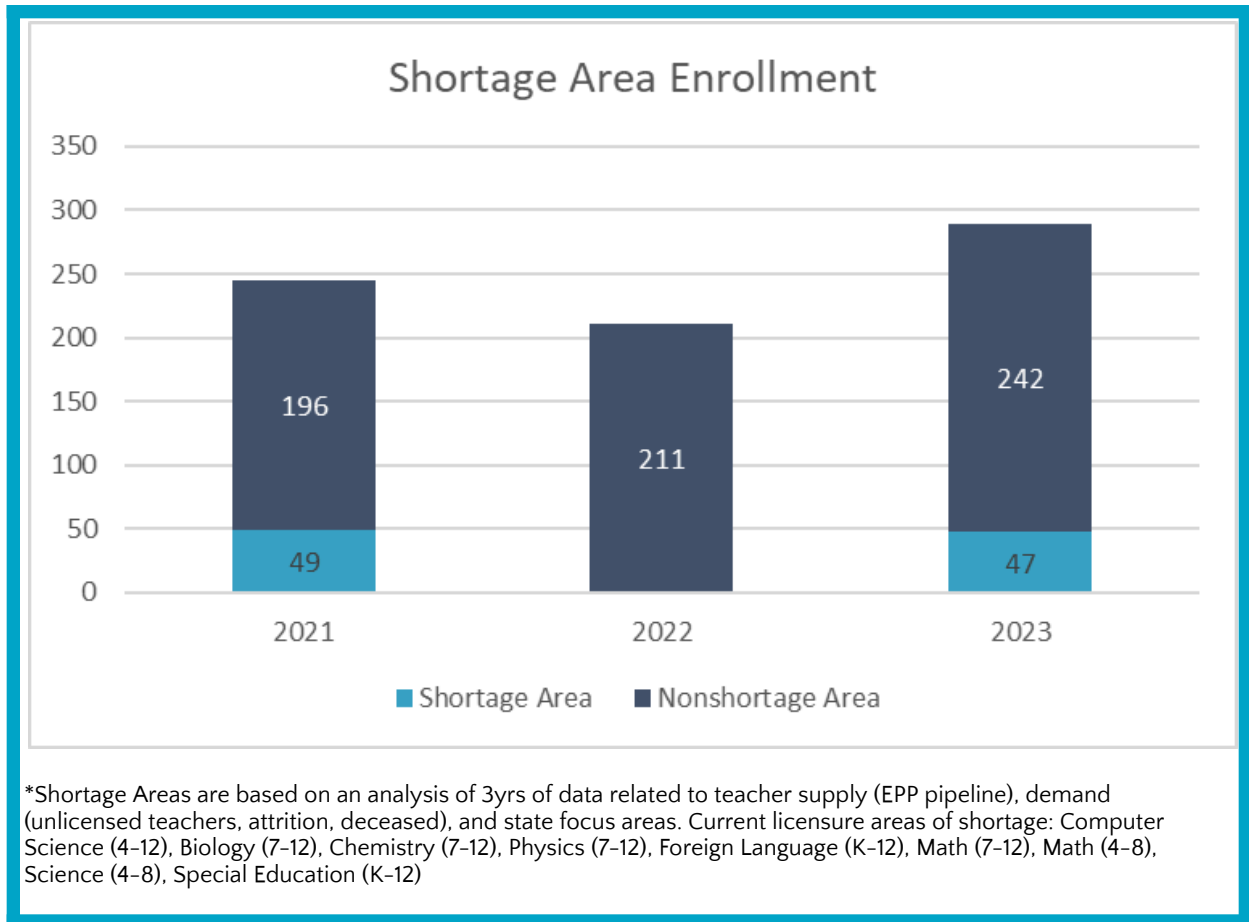
Enrollment

Metric is the percentage growth between blue and green boxes.

Year	Enrollment
2018	250
2019	188
2020	412
2021	245
2022	211
2023	289

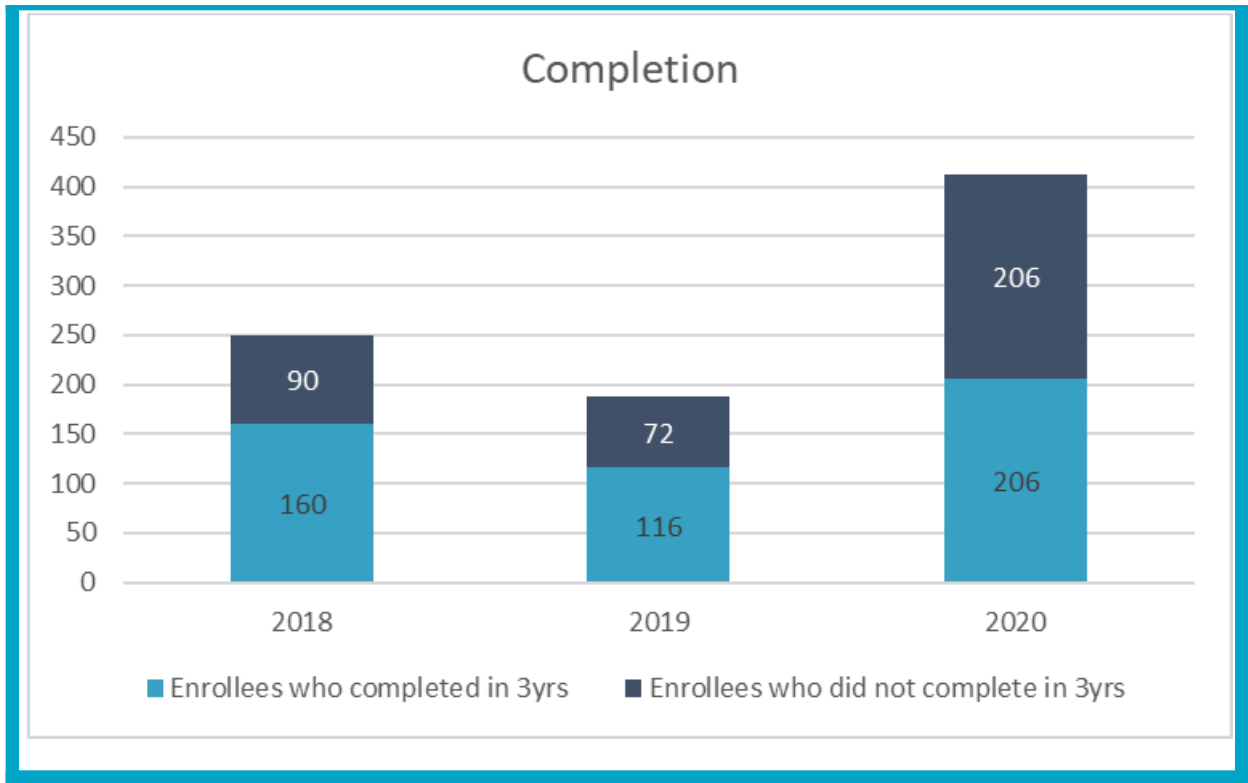
*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	13%	BELOW



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	58%	BELOW



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Out of 15 ArPEP sites across Arkansas, the following sites submitted documentation and provided focus group participants for the Standard 2 onsite review: Northwest Arkansas ESC (NWAESC), North Central ESC (NAESC), Arch Ford ESC (AFESC), Southwest Arkansas ESC (SWAEC)

Standard 2 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
Recommendations		
Site Facilitators are a strength of the ArPEP program, providing support to teachers in the classroom and sequencing school-year coursework to meet the current needs of their participants by connecting coursework to candidate teaching experiences. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: • Incorporate or continue to expand upon opportunities for teacher candidates to engage in English, math, and science HQIM within coursework so that candidates are familiar with the district curriculum and become day one ready. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1a Metric 1)</i> • Continue to refine a clear, intentional process to fully support candidates in their internship experience, including opportunities to expose them to a variety of experiences, even when they serve as a teacher of record. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2a Metric 2)</i> • Implement an evaluation process for course instructors that includes feedback from program directors, teacher candidates, and mentor teachers, targeting instructor knowledge, facilitation, and support <i>(Focus Area, Criteria 2.1c Metric 2)</i> • Begin utilizing the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and implement a formal observation cycle throughout the residency to analyze candidate effectiveness. <i>(Focus Area 2.3b Metric 3)</i>		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
APPROACHING
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction APPROACHING Program documents, including syllabi, handbooks, and site presentations, show that coursework aligns with the edTPA framework and provides scaffolded preparation for developing content-specific portfolios. Modules in the first year introduce protocols for internalizing the high-quality instructional materials (HQIM) used in candidates' classrooms, and presentations from the SWAEC and NWAEC sites reflected fidelity to the program's design. However,

there was no clear evidence that candidates were introduced to or supported with specific HQIMs, and documentation did not consistently address Science of Reading (SoR) awareness requirements. Only two AFESC candidates had completed the Arkansas IDEAS SoR pathway, and completion evidence was not found for the other sites.

In the Coursework focus group (n=6), about half of the participants reported using HQIM regularly, while others taught in content areas without identified HQIMs. Several participants noted learning about HQIM during Saturday coursework, though the sessions were described as general rather than content-specific. One candidate shared that coursework supported their understanding of best practices in lesson design, but few described examples of explicit instruction in evidence-based models or assessment strategies. Instructors (n=5) confirmed that lesson internalization routines are emphasized across sites, though the depth and consistency of HQIM integration varied.

Only one course was submitted as evidence, and that course covered classroom management, which did not provide any opportunity to observe instructional pedagogy. Although the review team had sufficient evidence from documentation and focus groups to determine that the EPP incorporates HQIM throughout coursework, there was no direct evidence regarding the extent or quality of HQIM development and support.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development
APPROACHING

Program documents, including syllabi, handbooks, and module overviews, show that coursework clearly familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K–12 standards within their licensure areas. Several modules address accessing and unpacking standards using ATLAS achievement level descriptors and proficiency scales. Presentations from NWAEC and NAESC demonstrated fidelity to the state-level overview, with NAESC also integrating opportunities for candidates to explore the use of AI in unpacking standards. However, documentation from other sites did not include evidence of similar implementation or candidate practice with vertical integration of standards. While one site presentation introduced the concept of comparing standards across grade levels, there was limited evidence that candidates vertically integrated standards in coursework across all sites.

In the Coursework focus group (n=6), participants from three of the four sites described coursework experiences that helped them “unpack standards and connect them to lesson planning.” One Year 1 participant shared that, as someone new to teaching, “the clear way we were introduced to standards helped me develop my first lesson plans.” Several candidates also noted being taught to examine standards above and below their assigned grade level, although this appeared more conceptual than consistently applied in practice. In the Course Instructor focus group (n=5), participants described how candidates “learn to unpack standards through the HQIM internalization process” and review the progression of standards to support differentiation, with one site intentionally grouping candidates across multiple grade levels to encourage natural discussion of vertical alignment.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
MEETS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses
MEETS

Program documents, including the ArPEP syllabus and the course sequence overview, demonstrate a clear, intentional sequencing of coursework across the two-year program. Year 1 establishes foundational teaching skills and aligns with standards, while Year 2 builds on those foundations by deepening practice, emphasizing data-driven instruction, and culminating in mastery of edTPA components. Modules are mapped to the Danielson Framework (TESS/ATS components 1a–4f), ensuring alignment between coursework, instructional expectations, and candidate evaluation. Documentation also indicates that Saturday sessions during the school year reinforce summer coursework and allow candidates to apply and extend their learning through progressively rigorous tasks.

In the Coursework focus group (n=4), all participants agreed that courses are intentionally sequenced to build from foundational concepts toward more complex instructional practice. Several candidates noted that early coursework focused on classroom management and student relationships, while later sessions incorporated instructional strategies and assessment. One participant remarked that the program felt “staggered in a good way,” with

higher-level topics introduced only after mastering the basics. Another described how the Saturday sessions “built off what we learned in the summer” and were timed to address relevant challenges throughout the school year.

In the Course Instructor focus group (n=5), participants explained that the two-year design intentionally scaffolds content to support candidate growth and readiness for edTPA. Instructors described introducing TESS and edTPA expectations early in Year 1 so candidates understand the developmental continuum of their learning and performance goals. Tasks related to the edTPA portfolio are distributed across both years, allowing for reinforcement, feedback, and opportunities to demonstrate increasing proficiency. Observations of session materials confirmed a clear developmental progression and consistent connections to prior learning, reflecting an intentional increase in rigor over time.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework MEETS

Program documents, including module slide decks and session materials, demonstrate that coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates the Arkansas Teaching Standards (ATS) to develop candidates who meet the knowledge and skills required for their licensure areas. Modules such as *Planning with Essential Standards*, *Instructional Strategies for Rigor & Relevance*, and *Lesson Internalization* are explicitly mapped to ATS Standards 1a–3e, addressing lesson design, instructional delivery, and assessment practices aligned with the InTASC/ATS framework. The integration of the TESS Teacher Rubric across multiple sessions—including *Building Positive Relationships*, *Formative Assessment*, and *Classroom Management and Trauma-Informed Practices*—further reflects alignment with ATS domains on The Learner and Learning, Instructional Practice, and Professional Responsibility.

In the Course Instructor focus group (n=5), participants emphasized that coursework sequencing intentionally mirrors the TESS/ATS framework to ensure candidates’ progressive mastery of the educator competencies. Year 1 coursework emphasizes the “learner and learning” cluster of ATS (TESS Domain 2), while Year 2 centers on “instructional practice” (TESS Domain 3). Observations confirmed this alignment: a classroom management session explicitly addressed Domain 2: Classroom Environment and ATS Standard 3: Learning Environments, supporting candidate reflection on effective routines and classroom culture.

In the observed classroom management session, reviewers noted ATS Standard 3: Learning Environments was incorporated. Observed coursework supported candidates in reflecting on the effectiveness of the procedures they used for establishing learning environments at the beginning of the year.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience MEETS

Program documents and assignment artifacts indicate that coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned with clinical experiences, ensuring that candidates apply learned concepts directly in their classroom settings. Field experience assignments require candidates to design detailed lesson plans aligned with standards, reflect on HQIM implementation, and develop a “Novice Teaching Manual” that guides new teachers and includes classroom management checklists, observation tools, and reflection prompts. These assignments bridge theory and practice, reinforcing candidates’ development in instructional design, differentiation, assessment, and formative feedback. Coursework is sequenced so candidates build foundational knowledge in the summer and apply it throughout the school year during their clinical placements.

In the Coursework focus group (n=4), participants consistently described strong alignment between coursework and their classroom experiences. One participant shared that “Saturday sessions help connect what we learned over the summer to what’s happening in our classrooms now.” Others emphasized the benefit of structured opportunities to reflect with instructors and peers, particularly after implementing new strategies. Candidates appreciated that sessions and assignments were “timed to match what’s happening in the school year,” such as classroom management early in the fall and assessment topics later in the year. These recurring opportunities to reflect and discuss classroom application reinforced their understanding of how coursework concepts translate into practice.

Instructors across all four sites described intentional connections between coursework and clinical supervision, noting that many instructors also serve as candidates’ clinical supervisors, further strengthening the coherence between learning and practice. They emphasized that reflection is embedded throughout the program, both to support edTPA preparation and to build habits of effective teaching. For example, the September session for Year 1 candidates includes guided reflection on classroom management implementation using strategies from the *CHAMPS* text.

Observation of this session confirmed that candidates actively analyzed their procedures from the first days of school and received feedback aligned with their coursework objectives.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors
MEETS

Program documents and instructor credential data indicate that most course instructors demonstrate deep knowledge of Arkansas K–12 standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy. Sixteen of twenty-one instructors (76%) have previous K–12 classroom experience, with three having taught within the past three years. Nearly all instructors (95%) hold a current teaching license, and more than half (52%) hold advanced degrees, such as Ed.D. or Ed. S. All instructors have completed Aspiring Teacher Rubric training, ensuring familiarity with key state-aligned competencies. While only a small percentage have recent content or HQIM-specific training, documentation shows that several instructors are currently completing NIET training to strengthen alignment between HQIM and instructional practice.

In the Coursework focus group (n=4), participants consistently described their instructors as knowledgeable, experienced, and grounded in practical classroom application. One participant explained that instructors “know the standards inside and out” and “give great examples that make things real.” Another noted that instructors “offer wise advice about how to handle classroom situations.” Participants also shared that when instructors lack specific content expertise, they readily connect candidates with content specialists at the cooperative who can provide additional support. This responsiveness reinforced candidates’ confidence that instructors were committed to ensuring their success in both pedagogy and content understanding.

In the Course Instructor focus group (n=5), participants described how they intentionally embed HQIM use and standards alignment within coursework. While two instructors had already completed HQIM training, others are part of an advisory group completing NIET training to extend this expertise across all sites. Instructors also reported ongoing professional learning tied to state initiatives such as John Wink’s leadership framework and Science of Reading implementation.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors
BELOW

Program documentation and available evidence show limited evidence that most course instructors have a proven history or consistent evidence of strong facilitation of coursework and of providing feedback and support. Instructor evaluation data were not provided, and only six candidate surveys from one site (AFESC) were available for review. The few artifacts submitted included a single example of written feedback on a lesson plan and several observation evaluations that did not clearly connect to coursework. Evidence of consistent or systematic instructor feedback processes across sites was not present. During the review, the team had access to only a few instructors, and without evaluation data to demonstrate a proven history and only one course observation showing strong facilitation or support, the team could not confirm that a majority of instructors met the standard.

In the Coursework focus group (n=4), participants described instructors as knowledgeable and supportive, stating that they “model best practices,” “ask questions that help you think deeper,” and “provide tailored feedback” on edTPA and coursework tasks. One candidate noted that instructors “use summer surveys to identify where we need more help,” suggesting individualized attention and responsiveness. Participants also emphasized that instructors’ K–12 teaching experience contributed to their credibility and ability to connect coursework to practice. However, while these perceptions were positive, the review team found little documentary or observed evidence to substantiate that such support was consistently implemented across all program sites.

The single observed course session provided limited evidence of strong facilitation. Although the instructor maintained pacing through structured tools such as graphic organizers and timers, opportunities for candidate discussion and engagement were minimal, and there was no evidence of ongoing feedback or instructional support tied to coursework.

Given the limited scope of course observations across sites, the team was unable to verify consistent facilitation or feedback practices program-wide.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

Program documentation shows that candidates begin with summer training sessions covering essential foundational topics such as classroom management, ethics in education, and the Teacher Excellence and Support System (TESS). Each site conducts a mandatory orientation to provide localized support at the outset. However, the materials—including the ArPEP Participant Handbook, 2025 Fall Orientation, and the Teacher Residency Handbook—do not describe a clearly scaffolded clinical sequence. The program explicitly states, “The clinical experience is not scaffolded, and ArPEP candidates assume full responsibility on day one.” While monthly sessions are offered on instructional strategies, engagement, assessment, and reflection, these are supplemental and not embedded in the clinical structure. No documentation submitted details how these sessions connect to or build upon candidates’ actual classroom practice across the two-year program.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=6), most candidates reported abrupt transitions into full teaching roles, with little structured progression. One candidate shared, “We were just thrown in with barely any preparation,” while another noted that, “It felt more like luck or my background that helped me, not something the program built in.” Some participants mentioned transitioning from roles such as paraprofessional to substitute to teacher of record, but participants did not report a clear or intentional build-up of responsibility or skills across the clinical experience. Clinical Supervisors described a sequence that begins with summer mock teaching and continues with full-time teaching in both year-one and year-two internships. However, supervisors did not describe a program-wide framework for gradually increasing expectations or skill development over the two years. One supervisor commented, “They’re in the classroom from day one—what they learn is mostly on the job.”

The reviewers noted that while the program provides some initial preparation and ongoing sessions, evidence from documents and focus groups indicates that clinical experiences are not clearly structured or scaffolded.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that candidates experience some variety in their clinical settings as the teacher of record, with opportunities to work with students with varied learning needs. The documentation specifically references students with exceptionalities within the *Special Education in Practice* course; however, no other student groups are explicitly identified.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), participants described limited but meaningful exposure to various instructional contexts, including special education and English learner settings. One participant noted experience working in an EL classroom, and several others mentioned completing observations in special education classrooms. Participants agreed that “the exposure to different student groups really depends on your placement,” suggesting that the variety of experiences was more a function of individual site assignments than of intentional program design. In the Clinical Supervisor focus group (n=5), participants explained that candidates progress from a summer mock-teaching experience to two years as teachers of record. Supervisors shared that “in larger districts, some candidates can observe other mentor teachers’ classrooms,” though they also noted that the provisional teaching model limits opportunities for broader exposure. Supervisors acknowledged that while some candidates gain valuable insights from varied contexts, this is not systematically ensured across placements, resulting in uneven experiences related to student and instructional variety.

Reviewers noted that although the candidates reported some exposure to different contexts, such as SPED and EL, these seemed more driven by the placement than by an intentional focus. There was little to no evidence of a systematic or comprehensive approach to ensuring varied clinical experiences across student populations.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

Evidence from documentation indicates that the program intends to strengthen its mentoring model by implementing a formal system of experienced mentor teachers beginning in 2026–2027. “Candidates are currently assigned mentors who provide valuable support”, however, documentation notes that the implementation of *experienced* mentor teachers, those with formal training and demonstrated coaching expertise, is not yet in place. The timeline for adoption of the new Mentoring Model is 2026–2027, which is aligned with the state guidance.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), all participants reported working with mentor teachers who provided consistent, context-specific guidance that directly supported their pedagogical development. One candidate shared that their mentor “teaches the same grade and is right next door,” allowing for daily interaction and immediate feedback, which they described as “a life changer.” Another candidate explained that their mentor “teaches the same subject, helps me with curriculum, and more—I am supported in the district.”

Although there were only two participants in the Experienced Mentor Teacher focus group (n=2), one mentor emphasized that “communication is key,” noting improved outcomes when mentors and candidates are well-matched. Another described helping candidates “notice the strategy and use their data to make a strategy that is best practice for them,” reflecting an understanding of adult learning and reflective coaching. Both reported frequent, informal meetings—“between classes, after school, or at lunch”—to discuss instructional practices.

Note: By 2026–2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#)

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that, while all ArPEP candidates at the reviewed sites are currently assigned mentors, a formalized process for identifying and selecting experienced mentor teachers has not yet been implemented. The documentation notes that the structured selection process—based on defined criteria such as years of experience, demonstrated instructional effectiveness, and pedagogical expertise—is planned for full rollout in the 2026–2027 school year. The provided artifact, the *ArPEP Teacher Residency Handbook*, includes a one-page outline draft describing the intended model but lacks details on current implementation procedures or established criteria.

In the School Partner focus group (n=5), participants described clear, district-level processes for selecting mentor teachers using specific criteria related to experience and instructional effectiveness. One participant explained that South Conway County SD looks for teachers who “are effective in evaluation, or have a high VAM score, successful with students, and match grade level and subject.” Another shared that Elkins School District requires all ArPEP mentors to be lead or master teachers who “must go through cognitive coaching or another pathway” and “have a meeting with leadership to ensure they know the expectations.”

The reviewers noted that while the School Partner focus group stressed the selection process and its criteria, there was insufficient evidence elsewhere of a formalized system for experienced mentor selection, training, or evaluation.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Evidence from documentation indicates that the formal clinical supervisor model has not yet been implemented within the ArPEP program. The EPP notes that “ArPEP site facilitators currently serve in a support role and will transition into the clinical supervisor role once the model is formally launched.”

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), all participants reported working with individuals they identified as clinical supervisors who provided both emotional and instructional support. One candidate shared that their supervisor “offered thoughtful and insightful feedback using the rubric during classroom observations,” while another explained, “I called them crying; did I do this wrong? It was overwhelming, but their understanding, encouragement, and classroom experience helped me be positive and grow.” Participants agreed that their supervisors are active, their feedback is structured, personalized, and focused on growth, reflecting effective coaching practices that positively influence candidate development.

Observational evidence indicates that clinical supervisors demonstrate strong instructional and coaching skills, with a measurable impact on candidate growth. During an observed coaching session, the supervisor facilitated reflection by asking questions such as “What do you think went well?” and “How might you adjust next time?” The feedback was specific and actionable, aligned to Domain 2 of the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, and highlighted strengths in classroom organization, positive reinforcement, and proximity. The supervisor also guided the candidate in identifying gaps in student learning and in adjusting pacing and behavioral management strategies.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates
APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that, while the program aspires to provide targeted, evidence-based feedback aligned with student learning outcomes, the formal clinical supervisor model responsible for delivering this feedback has not yet been fully implemented. Candidates serving as teachers of record receive evaluative feedback through the Teacher Excellence and Support System (TESS), rather than the Aspiring Teacher Rubric (ATR). The submitted documentation does not include concrete examples of written supervisor feedback or evidence of a systematic feedback cycle among mentors, supervisors, and candidates.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), all participants reported receiving regular feedback from clinical supervisors (Site Facilitators), and most described it as clear, actionable, and connected to instructional practice. All candidates reported receiving written feedback, and five indicated that feedback built upon prior observations—for example, progressing “from classroom management to scaffolding and grouping strategies.” One participant shared that “our supervisor would email the mentor teacher to make sure they are checking in here on this and this, or can you make sure she understands these things and inputting grades and tracking RTI,” describing how feedback often addressed both instructional and procedural growth. While candidates consistently perceived the feedback as supportive and relevant, they did not reference a formal or standardized system for documenting or tracking this input.

In the Clinical Supervisor (Site Facilitator) focus group (n=3), participants described providing both verbal and written feedback to candidates, including commentary on lesson implementation and technical tasks. One participant noted, “We have a tracker as well... we create a link once a task is processed,” while another stated, “We watch 30 minutes and give verbal and written feedback that goes directly to the principal.” Supervisors acknowledged recent improvements, including a feedback tracker developed in the past two months, but also reported challenges maintaining consistency due to workload and candidate volume. Mentor teachers could not provide examples of feedback or observation data shared between themselves and supervisors.

Observational evidence shows that when feedback is provided, it is specific, frequent, and grounded in observable classroom evidence. During a coaching observation, the mentor offered oral feedback aligned to Domain 2 of the TESS Rubric, noting both strengths and areas for growth. Feedback was linked to student outcomes—identifying that several students had not retained the letter *n* from a prior lesson—and guided the candidate to plan targeted small-group instruction.

The review team noted that while some candidates reported receiving frequent, written, and oral feedback linked to student learning and built on prior observations, including information from the mentor teacher focus groups and document review, there appeared to be inconsistent implementation and a lack of a standard, formalized feedback system across the program and only saw evidence of the TESS rubric rather than the Aspiring Teacher Rubric.

Note: The Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by EPPs by the 2024–25 academic year.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools
APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that communication between the EPP and partner districts primarily focuses on operational coordination such as planning professional learning sessions or scheduling site visits, rather than on co-constructing the clinical internship experience. While documentation reflects a consistent exchange of logistical

information, there is limited evidence of reciprocal planning, shared decision-making, or structured collaboration processes that intentionally align program expectations with district needs or candidate development goals.

In the Experienced Mentor Teacher focus group (n=2), both participants reported no direct collaboration with ArPEP staff. One mentor explained, "I have not met with their clinical supervisor (site facilitator) or anyone from ArPEP," while the other confirmed, "There's no requirement for me to contact her." Neither mentor teacher had attended orientation or training provided by the EPP before mentoring candidates, and both indicated they had not been asked to provide feedback on the clinical experience. Mentors noted that materials were sent from the program coordinator, but described this as "one-way communication," reflecting a lack of formal partnership or shared structures for ongoing collaboration between the EPP and school-based mentors.

In the Partnership focus group (n=5), all participants described active and generally positive relationships with ArPEP, highlighting frequent communication and responsiveness from program staff. One district leader shared, "We work closely with the coop and have a partner and resource in place to make sure our candidates are on track for licensure." Another noted that "NC coop is on our campus a lot and checking in with our candidates," and several participants emphasized that ArPEP staff "come out often to monitor them in the classroom." Multiple district representatives described the EPP as "responsive" and "an extension of our staff," emphasizing accessibility and open lines of communication. One participant provided one example of co-construction, explaining that when a mid-year cohort was needed, "ArPEP listened and helped us to make this happen."

Reviewers found that some evidence of communication and collaboration with clinical supervisors exists; however, it reflects isolated or logistical interactions rather than consistent, collaborative processes to develop and strengthen the clinical experience.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that while site facilitators are currently fulfilling the responsibilities of clinical supervisors, there is no formal or consistent structure in place to support or develop individuals in this role. The documentation states that "while the formal role of clinical supervisors is not currently implemented, site facilitators are serving in that capacity to ensure candidates receive the guidance and support necessary for success in their clinical experiences." This arrangement demonstrates an effort to support candidates but also reveals inconsistency, as site facilitators often manage multiple responsibilities, limiting their capacity to provide systematic supervision and development across all candidates.

In the Clinical Supervisors focus group (n=3), participants did not reference any EPP-provided training, calibration meetings, or shared tools to ensure alignment in expectations or feedback to candidates.

Given that clinical supervisors have multiple responsibilities within the ESC and that there is no formalized system for their development, there is no evidence of consistency across the program.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework APPROACHING

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework MEETS

Evidence from documentation indicates that most candidates demonstrate proficiency in coursework and clinical internship requirements. ArPEP Teacher Evaluation data show that 79% of candidates were rated *Effective*, 4% *Highly Effective*, and 16% *Progressing*. Performance by program further supports overall proficiency, with Arch Ford reporting 81% of candidates rated *Highly Effective* or *Effective* (n=21), Northwest 95% *Effective* (n=20), Southwest 57% *Effective* (n=14), and Northcentral 100% *Effective* (n=12). The edTPA is used as a key clinical assessment milestone, and candidates who do not initially meet the passing standard may retake the edTPA or pass the Principles of Learning and Teaching (PLT) exam as an alternative.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework
APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that candidates who fall behind in coursework are expected to receive individualized support through a Letter of Concern outlining deadlines and guidelines for improvement. Programs use tracking spreadsheets to monitor progress on licensure requirements, coursework completion, and field experience milestones. These tools track elements such as attendance, lesson plan submissions, and completion of required trainings (e.g., Science of Reading, AR History). However, while the documentation demonstrates systematic tracking, there is limited evidence that individualized support plans are co-developed with candidates or that candidates actively monitor their own progress. Tracking forms rely primarily on checkboxes rather than narrative feedback or documented interventions, and it is unclear how data triggers targeted support.

In the Course Instructor focus group (n=8), participants reported that they provide additional help to struggling candidates, particularly around edTPA preparation and coursework completion, but that there is no formal process for creating individualized support plans. One instructor shared that “we meet with candidates one-on-one when they are struggling, but it’s more informal – there isn’t a set plan.” Another noted that principals or mentor teachers sometimes coordinate with ArPEP staff to provide candidates time during the school day to receive additional support. While these actions demonstrate responsiveness, the process appears ad hoc and dependent on instructor initiative rather than a consistent, program-wide system.

Observation and course review confirmed that instructors monitor candidate progress and offer guidance during class sessions, but no formal documentation of individualized support plans or structured progress monitoring was observed. Overall, evidence across documents, focus groups, and observations indicates that candidate support is strong but inconsistent, with individualized plans provided in some cases but lacking a uniform structure across the program.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones
APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates that programs have limited formal documentation outlining a complete set of clinical internship goals and milestones. Existing tracking focuses on broad program requirements such as Praxis passage, edTPA, FOR, Ethics, and IDEAS training, but does not clearly define specific, measurable internship goals or show systematic monitoring of progress. It is unclear whether evaluations are conducted by school principals or ArPEP faculty, and there is no evidence of analysis to inform program improvement or identify trends.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), five candidates reported knowing their goals and milestones, and four indicated understanding how to track progress. However, most responses focused on personal growth plan goals rather than program-defined internship goals. One candidate stated, “We set goals at the end of one school year for the next,” and “address them at PLC meetings,” while another noted that their coordinator “checked in at times to monitor progress.” These responses suggest awareness of general expectations but limited clarity or formal tracking of program-level milestones.

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group (n=3), participants described recent efforts to clarify program expectations through a shared checklist outlining all due dates and required products for the two-year internship. One supervisor explained, “Transparency is key. This year has been our strongest year. No one is late or absent. It’s been the best because of a collaborative document given to students.” Supervisors also highlighted an ArPEP drive for sharing resources and monthly Zoom meetings to support communication and candidate tracking. While these efforts reflect improvements in guidance and monitoring, they are relatively new and are not yet fully embedded as a consistent, program-wide system.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth
APPROACHING

Evidence from documentation indicates limited evidence that candidates directly impact student growth. While TESS evaluation data show that 79% of candidates were rated *Effective* and 4% *Highly Effective*, these ratings reflect overall teaching performance rather than measurable student learning outcomes. The program asserts that “Effective” ratings

strongly indicate contribution to student growth, but no direct evidence—such as pre/post assessments, value-added measures, or documented learning gains—is provided. Without this data, the capacity of candidates to influence student learning cannot be fully determined.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), all participants reported regularly engaging with student data and using it to guide instruction. One candidate shared using DIBELS data “at least once a week, if not daily,” while another noted that students “set their own goals and we check in twice a month to see if they’re having success.” However, these examples reflected individual initiative rather than a consistent, program-wide expectation for data-driven practice. Mentor focus group feedback was also mixed: one mentor described regular collaboration on data analysis, while another reported little evidence of candidates using data to guide instruction. In the Clinical Supervisor focus group (n=2), supervisors described reviewing classroom trends and supporting candidates’ use of student data, though practices were inconsistent across year levels. One supervisor explained, “We come back as a team and talk about what we see. If we see trends, we build this into summer training.” Another noted, “I would love to be more intentional about how year two candidates are using student data...we don’t ask year one teachers as they are too new.”

Observational evidence supports that some candidates demonstrate the capacity to impact student growth. During an observed coaching session, the candidate analyzed student performance, noting that several students had not retained the letter *n* and proposing small-group instruction. The supervisor reinforced this approach through reflective questioning, and the candidate provided individualized support by working directly with a student who needed additional guidance.

Overall, the available evidence indicates that some candidates are developing the capacity to use student data and instructional strategies to promote learning, but direct or systematic evidence of student growth impact is limited.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

BELOW

Evidence from documentation indicates that candidates are not evaluated using the Aspiring Teacher Rubric at the end of their clinical internship. Instead, assessments are conducted using the TESS framework, with 79% of candidates rated *Effective*, 4% *Highly Effective*, and 16% *Progressing*. Program-level performance varies: Arch Ford (81% *Highly Effective* or *Effective*, n=21), Northwest (95% *Effective*, n=20), Southwest (57% *Effective*, n=14), and Northcentral (100% *Effective*, n=12).

While these data show general teaching competence, the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is the required evaluation measure for this metric. Without evidence that candidates are scored on this rubric, it cannot be determined whether any candidate meets the standard of *effective* teaching at the conclusion of the clinical internship. Additionally, it is unclear whether evaluations occur at the end of the internship and who conducts them, leaving the timing and consistency of the assessments unknown.

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

MEETS

Evidence from documentation shows that candidates with varied needs are provided structured support throughout the clinical internship. The NAESC Mentoring Program outlines responsibilities and goals for mentors who, in turn, support program candidates. Struggling candidates receive a Letter of Concern with deadlines, guidelines, and targeted support, while the Year 2 Personal PD Plan provides a personalized professional development roadmap aligned to licensure and instructional goals. These supports primarily target program completion, but they establish consistent mechanisms for addressing candidate needs.

In the Clinical Experience focus group (n=7), participants reported receiving the support they needed, including individualized assistance when necessary. Candidates emphasized the value of peer support, noting that monthly cohort meetings allow them to “share ideas and cheer each other on,” and they receive actionable feedback from administrators and supervisors. One candidate explained that when building-level support was insufficient, guidance from the ESC helped fill gaps, indicating that multiple layers of support exist to address candidate needs.

Observational evidence confirms that candidates receive individualized support that addresses both challenges and strengths. During a coaching session, the mentor identified areas of difficulty, including student retention and

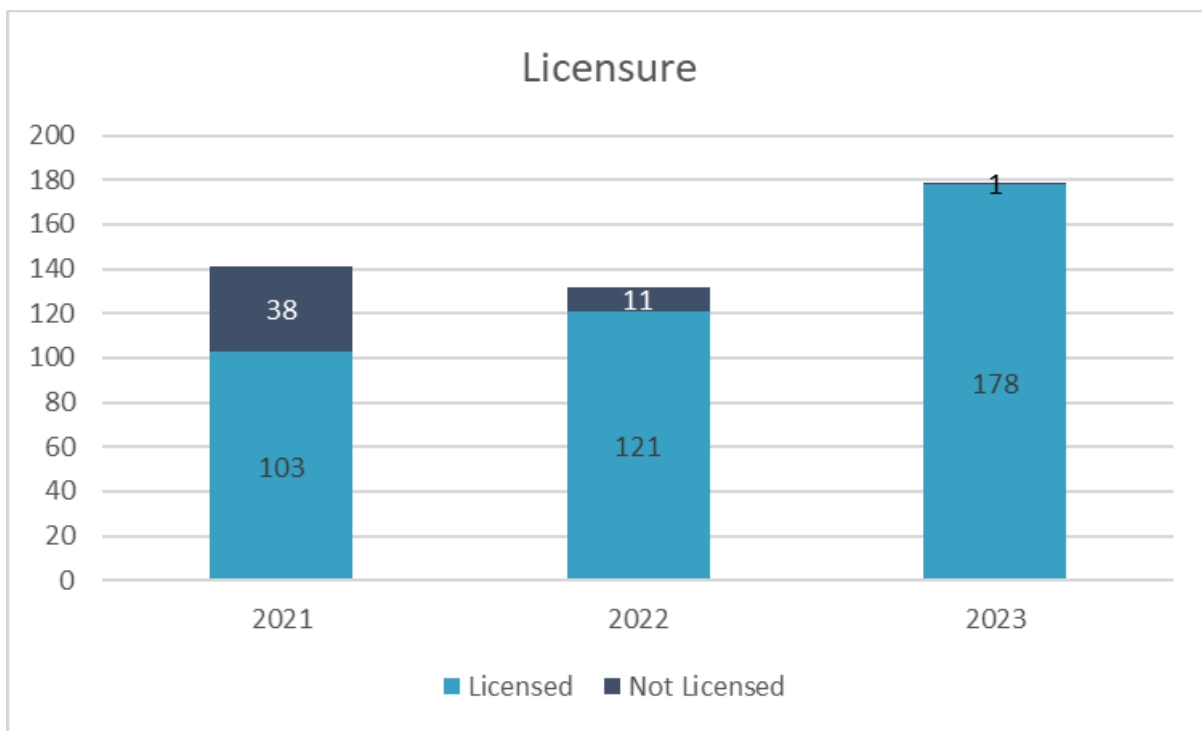
attention, and prompted the candidate to propose solutions such as small-group instruction. The mentor also acknowledged effective classroom management, positive reinforcement, and the candidate's ability to meet individual student needs, demonstrating active candidate engagement in developing her own support plan.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
EXCEEDS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS	MEETS
Recommendations		
Recommendations include: Analyze EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b</i>)		

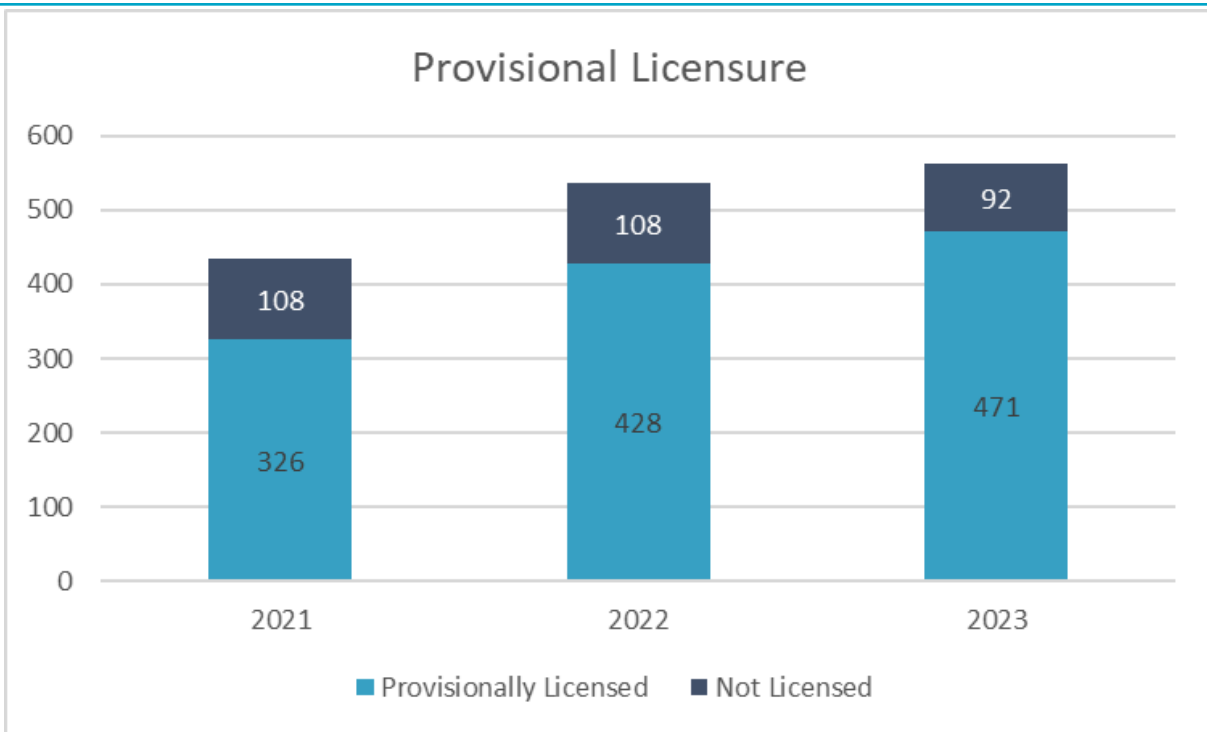
INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license within one year of completion	80%	89%	EXCEEDS



Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	79.9%	EXCEEDS



Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	n/a	n/a

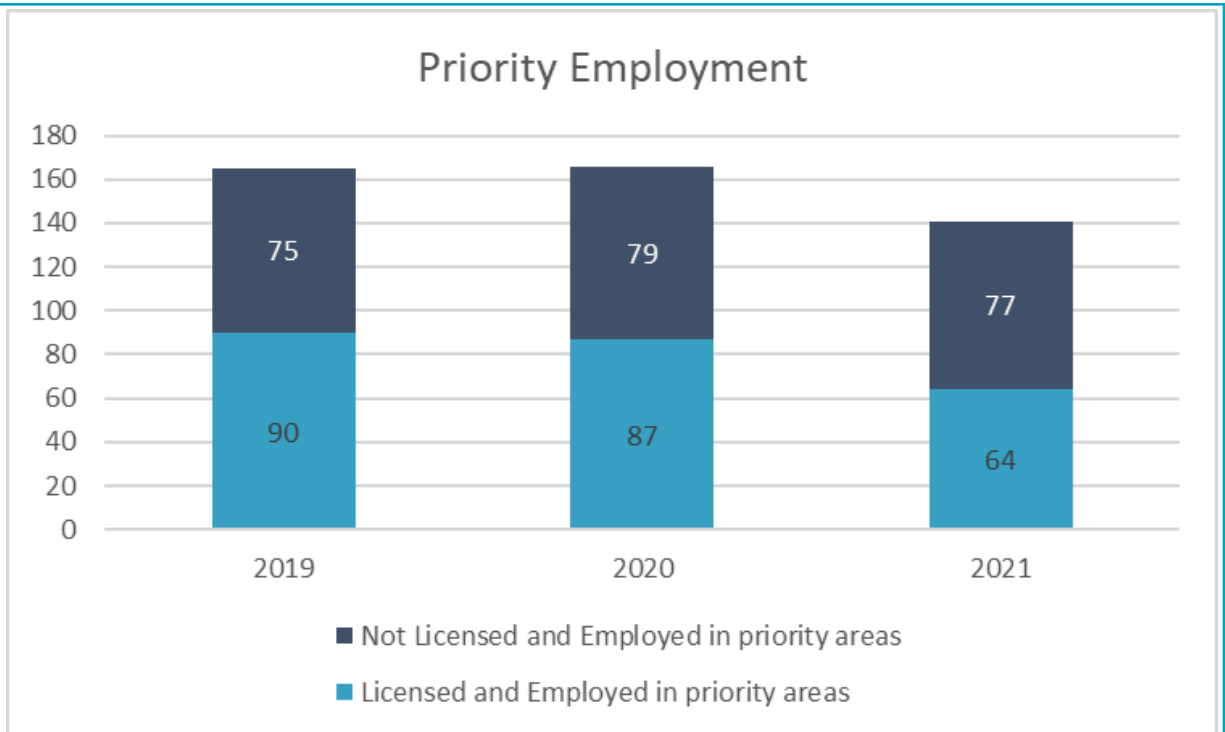
INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	83.7%	EXCEEDS

Employment

Year	Licensed and Employed	Not Licensed and Employed
2019	145	20
2020	138	28
2021	112	29

Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	39%	51.1%	EXCEEDS



*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.8	2.22	EXCEEDS

INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	84.9%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	57.8%	BELOW
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	45%	EXCEEDS

